film *The Big Sick* (2017), are some prominent South Asians making a mark in the western film industry.

In March this year, Priyanka and her manager, Anjula Acharia, hosted a South Asian Excellence pre-Oscars party at Paramount Studios. "I still get emotional about it...the idea was to show that we are not alone, that we have each other," says Priyanka about the night. The attendees included Guneet Monga and Kartiki Gonsalves, the makers of *The Elephant Whisperers* (2022), and Chandrabose, the lyricist of *RRR*'s (2022) hit track 'Naatu Naatu'. Priyanka says she intends to make the soiree an annual ritual. "We are one of the largest film industries in the world.... Why don't we have presence in English-language entertainment?"

This is precisely what motivates her. Priyanka has signed a first-look television deal with Amazon and recently announced that she will star in and co-produce another limited series, *Assume Nothing*, based on Sri Lankan-American film producer Tanya Selvaratnam's memoir. Next up after *Citadel* is a Hollywood rom-com, *Love Again*, which releases in May. "There are multiple other projects I am doing that have Indians and South Asians in front of and behind the camera," she says. "It's my quest. Now that I have a foundation in America, I want to be the shoulders that I never had." ■

**Suhani Singh**

ORIGINALS

# MURDER IN THE BACKYARD

**A web series revisits the dark saga of Shakereh Khaleeli, who was killed by her 'godman' husband Swami Shraddhanand**

Filmmaker Patrick Graham of *Leila* (2019) fame hadn't done a documentary series since his film school days, but when he got an opportunity to dive into the world of Shakereh Khaleeli, he could not let it go. "The narrative is such a twisting thriller that it appealed to the storyteller in me," says Graham.

The unfortunate Khaleeli, who came from an aristocratic family of Persian descent, is best remembered as the woman whose body was found in a box in the backyard of her own house in Bengaluru. It took the police three years to find her remains. What makes it more gruesome is the possibility that the 44-year-old was buried alive. The culprit: her second husband, Murali Manohar Mishra a.k.a. Swami Shraddhanand, who is currently serving a life sentence. In *Dancing on the Grave* (full disclosure: the series is an India Today Originals production) on Amazon Prime Video, Graham tries to unravel the enigma that Shakereh was and, in the process, figure out who Mishra is.

The first two episodes of the four-part series paint a portrait of Shakereh, a mother to four daughters with the diplomat husband she would later divorce, and trace the circumstances that led her to a godman like Mishra. The religious and class divide in the relationship is touched upon through the talking heads format. The ostracisation that Shakereh faced from her own family after she married Mishra led to an environment of isolation and vulnerability.



(Top) A still from the series shows Shakereh Khaleeli and Murali Manohar Mishra; (bottom) director Patrick Graham

It's one of the many mysterious aspects about Shakereh that drew Chandni A. Dabas, Business Head, Originals & Special Projects at INDIA TODAY GROUP, to her story. "The motivation was always the woman, not the man.... She was this bold woman who took the call of stepping out of her marriage. What if she had succeeded? Unfortunately, tragedy struck," says Dabas, adding that she hopes revisiting the case will start a conversation and offer a reminder for caution in matters of the heart.

If the series leaves you with more questions than answers, then that is intentional, say both Dabas and Graham. "We can only decipher, for she [Shakereh] is not here to tell her story, and give our theory of what happened, according to the people who spoke to us and the core documents and evidence we have," says Graham. "It is not prescriptive; it is almost presumptuous of us to suggest that this is what you should think."

The masterstroke is an interview with Mishra himself in jail. For Graham and Dabas, giving him a forum was a way "to delve into the mind of someone capable of doing something so heinous". As he is nudged about the fateful day, his three-year silence and attempts to mislead Sabah, Shakereh's daughter, one sees a man who clearly understood the consequences of his actions but remained in denial about just how terrible they were. ■

**Suhani Singh**

